

camera. That said, in the higher camcorder models, you do get digital camera quality stills, though at that price you might want to focus on other, more important features.

1.2.5. Focus

Focusing is what you (or the camcorder) do to bring the picture into sharp, clear detail. At the budget end, focus control is mostly automatic, that is, the camcorder makes the best judgement it can about the focus required, and adjusts the lens accordingly. As you go up the scale, you can get either a jog dial (a circular dial) or buttons to manually adjust the focus. However, for ultimate control over focus—and this is relevant when you're trying to get those soft focus shots, for example when you want to give a dream like quality to your scene—you need a focus ring around the lens which you can alternate between manual and automatic as required. Also, you should note that autofocus mode is not completely hassle free. When you are panning (moving the camcorder), the autofocus mechanism goes into “hunting” mode, searching for a “target” to lock on to. During this period there might be a bit of a bit of a blur as the auto-

